

KRISHNENDU HALDER

"The concept of *sewa* has transformed from free langar in gurudwaras to extending help to the needy at all times."

Tejdeep often applies for relief funds from the government, and seeks donations from members of the Sikh community as well as the professional support of doctor members who offer it for free. . "We also get donations from Sikhs across the country, and funds from the Guru Nanak Mission Trust and the CSR programmes of the Electronic Mart of India, CARE Hospitals Group, South Indian Bank, Lawrence & Mayo, among others," she says.

Health apart, TSS is also helping Sikligars get permanent housing and title rights for land. In Nirmal, TSS helped 36 families that had lived for three generations as nomads get shelter and 2BHK homes for the first time. In 2023, the government gave title rights to occupants of 45 acres of land on which they had built homes or businesses in the Sikh Chawni. Earlier, in 2019, municipal authorities were persuaded to give title rights to 55 Sikligar families living in a 2,000 square yard area in Bodhan when they were about to be evicted.

TSS has also worked to renovate toilet blocks, school buildings and provide financial support to those who might have lost their homes to environmental disruptions in the state. It has also established skilling centres to hone the tailoring and computer skills of women and girls and held residential camps for poor students from across the state to help them find motivation and a positive outlook to improve their quality of life. ■

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HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

↘ Took overall charge of the impoverished Sikligar community during the Covid years, looking after their health, hospitalisation, food and financial needs

↘ It has also helped them get housing and land title rights and set up skilling centres for them to improve their skills

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